

## **MAKING YOUR OWN DECISIONS**

### **GOALS OF THE EXERCISE**

1. Identify decisions that have been avoided.
2. Identify decisions that will be made independently in the future.
3. Implement positive self-talk to build confidence in decision-making.

### **ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL**

- Depression
- Grief/Loss Unresolved
- Low Self-Esteem

### **SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT**

Decision-making is anxiety-producing in people who have developed a pattern of dependency on others or have lost confidence in their own abilities. This exercise is focused on assisting the client to acknowledge the pattern of avoidance of decisions, to commit to making specified decisions, and to build confidence through positive self-talk. Point out the client's distorted cognitive messages that contribute to low self-esteem and assist him/her in listing replacement messages that are more realistic and positive. Reinforce all steps toward independent functioning and decision-making.

## MAKING YOUR OWN DECISIONS

When you develop a habit of dependence on others, you commonly avoid making your own decisions. You postpone or project responsibility for decisions onto others. Often, this pattern extends to even the small decisions of daily living, such as what time to eat, what meal to prepare, what time to go to bed, whether to call a friend or family member, or whether to make a small purchase.

1. **Decisions I Have Let Others Make:** List 10 decisions that you have avoided making in the recent past.

- A. \_\_\_\_\_
- B. \_\_\_\_\_
- C. \_\_\_\_\_
- D. \_\_\_\_\_
- E. \_\_\_\_\_
- F. \_\_\_\_\_
- G. \_\_\_\_\_
- H. \_\_\_\_\_
- I. \_\_\_\_\_
- J. \_\_\_\_\_

2. **Decisions I Will Make:** List 10 decisions you will make in the near future without seeking out unnecessary reassurance and direction from others.

- A. \_\_\_\_\_
- B. \_\_\_\_\_
- C. \_\_\_\_\_
- D. \_\_\_\_\_
- E. \_\_\_\_\_
- F. \_\_\_\_\_
- G. \_\_\_\_\_
- H. \_\_\_\_\_

- I. \_\_\_\_\_
- J. \_\_\_\_\_

3. **Positive Self-Talk:** List 5 positive messages you can give to yourself that will help you make decisions more confidently (e.g., I am a capable person, I have the intelligence necessary to make reasonable decisions, I have researched this issue enough to make an informed and logical decision).

- A. \_\_\_\_\_
- B. \_\_\_\_\_
- C. \_\_\_\_\_
- D. \_\_\_\_\_
- E. \_\_\_\_\_